



Artmatr

MTF

MYSTERIUM, TREMENDUM et FASCINANS

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TRANSCENDENCE AND ART

The last two years I have been working on a painting series called sublime machines. It was a series where I felt compelled to infuse human intent to algorithms and geometries, trying to evoke new types of transcendent experiences that are more relevant for our present time. For people like me, who seek a higher truth, but for who God or Science just doesn't cut it.

While I was working on these, my brother Karthik and I were having conversations about these paintings and also about an idea that moved us personally: the idea that we can be more than ourselves, or at least try to be, in other words, transcendence again. We were interested less in theories (religious or psychological) that explained transcendence but in the quality of the experience itself and the power it can have to alter one's life path. We learnt that there were three key aspects of any transcendent experience: We borrowed from a religious theorist Rudolf Otto's definition of the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*: an attractive yet awe-inspiring mystery.

So in other words, there were three elements to such an experience :

A feeling of liberation - from the past, from ourselves, from all sorts of constraints, - this of course was also a feeling of loss of identity - which can induce tremendous fear and loss of a sense of control over one's life- and finally being comfortable with the confusing feeling of mystery of what is to come

We agreed that the encounter with transcendent art is something that both draws you in and unsettles you. Moreover because such art is never the solution to a mystery but is the mystery itself, and can never be reduced to pure idea, it has the power to keep us feeling unsettled. What we were exploring in a sense, was the value of us thinking of ourselves as an (art)work in process, rather than as a finished settled identity. My brother and I started 64/1, an art collective to explore this idea further, and published a thesis on transcendence for the digital anthropocene in Critical Collective.



A CRUEL IRONIC JOKE

While I was right in the middle of working on this series on transcendence, like a cruel ironic joke, my wife (after 17 years of being together - and having no doubt about the stability of my relationship) suddenly questioned the entire basis of our relationship. It broke my heart and I could feel the ground beneath my feet crumble.

Suddenly, transcendence was not some theoretical exercise anymore. I was going through it. Everything that I had taken to be absolute and true, taken to be the unquestioned truth on which I had built my sense of life and its purpose, just fell apart. I was angry. I felt dead. I felt desperate and alone.

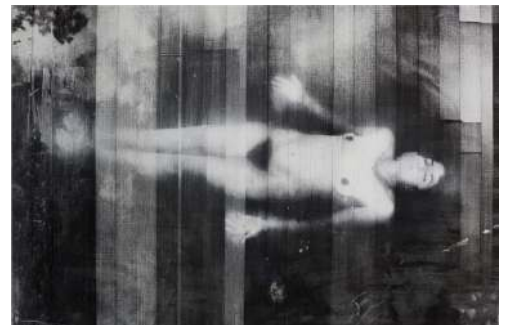
I called my friend and shared my state with them. They asked me "Do you love Netra the person or Netra the role - the wife/mother?" Only then did it occur to me that these were two different distinct things and I might be confusing the two and if I was to remain true to my sense of the transcendent, I needed to face this confusion head on.

We are not just the roles that the world imposes on us. We are capable of being other than what the world, or the part of society that we internalize, tells us we are. A large part of our life is indeed determined by our roles, our position in society, in history, but there was a crucial remainder that lived in change and for the future! Without this remainder where's the reason for hope, for change, for action?

I knew all this but why was it so difficult for me to let go of my idea of my role?

This experience was certainly terrifying - I can't even imagine a life without Netra. Everything I celebrated in my life was around us. I celebrated how well we know each other, how we can predict each other, how we do everything together. My whole life there's been one fixture and it's been us. All of this was now falling apart.

It was like falling off a cliff. But you know, strangely, it was also liberating because suddenly my life was not scripted anymore, it felt open to improvisation, to possibility. Moreover it was mysterious because I had no clue what was to come and I had to learn to be comfortable with that.





MY TRUE SELF

How often do we stop to ask ourselves what is our true self?

I believe that my true self is quite different from my everyday self which is caught up in beliefs and desires - things that make me feel needy and addicted to people, things and places. And here is something I started to realize: perhaps all of life was change and motion to give our hidden true selves, our spirit a chance to manifest - a chance for us to discover and experience the self hidden within us?

Then another friend of mine asked me something that made me stop and rethink. They said - Have you taken the time to ask yourself "What does this Raghava want? instead of telling me that Netra and I had promised ourselves all these things when we were 18 and 20 -- can you accept that you both are new people?"

It was such a shock. I used to take such pride in thinking we both knew each other so well. The very thing I was proud of was the cause of our stagnation. The idea that I could 'know' her, she could 'know' me. This idea of a settled knowledge, the idea of us as Homo Sapiens. The apes who "know". Know what we are, know our place in society, or to use a common critical cliché, our 'situatedness'

Right in the middle of a heated discussion, when Netra was questioning the fundamentals of our relationship. We were driving each other mad and bringing out the worst in each other. We were not able to use words to communicate. I wasn't able to tell her she had turned into another person (I even google searched what if your partner turns into another person) Everything about her was different, the way she dressed the way she acted, everything. So I asked her if i could take pictures in the cold water of our pond. To express and acknowledge that my Netra is dead, and a new Netra is reborn. I walked into the freezing water fully clothed until I was nearly submerged, both of us were in extreme discomfort both physically and emotionally as she obliged to be my muse for the last time.

I purposely did not want to focus on the past, but to focus on transcendence. I am not showing pictures of us on a holiday or when our kids were born. But of her transcending. This photo is inspiring because it represents a transcendent moment and forces me to ask myself who am I?

Each picture - each reworking is unique, this represents how she can be anything moving forward. Some of them are haunting some of the are beautiful, some of the are ugly, some of them are ghostly. Each one is bringing up the different emotions of transcendence. These pictures represent that "I love you and I'm gonna miss you" and the "Fuck yous" Can be with the same people in the same conversation and the same moment.

When I place Netra in different situations - it tells me more about my own projection of her and less about who she is. She is a mirror to me. In the one sense this is the MTF, she draws me in and repels me at the same time.

It feels like all of the different stages of transcendence, anger, frustration, despair, love, beauty, rebirth etc... (which are not linear and neither are these works) are represented in these works.

The marks done by the printer make me feel that there's a relationship between the digital and the real. Everytime you recall a memory, you're altering it. Every pixel stored in the computer is a memory and everytime I recreate that work, I am recalling it and changing it. This represents that I don't know how to remember Netra, everytime I recall her I'm rewriting how I feel about her.

This is a ritual of letting go, as the series continues It gets more and more abstracted and Netra dissolves.

It's forced me to ask myself what do I want. I did not know how to enjoy a chocolate without her. It's forcing me to enjoy things on my own and to be my own person. To take care of the spirit within me. I realized that we all die when we don't take care of our spirits. I was being an escapist.

I have always been against being put in a box. For example, I really don't know what 'being male' means. It makes no sense at all to me. I have learnt over a period of time what others expect of my being male. But I am sick of confusing social expectations with my sense of self and the identity politics that come with it.

People usually explain my existence in two ways

1. Nature - Male, Hetrosexual, Indian, Genetics
2. Nurture - Upbringing, Exposure, Schooling etc.

But there is a third one that is much more important for me

3. Imagination - It is who I want to become.



ONE TRUTH: WE ARE HOMO MUTANS

So in effect what I was learning was to live FOR the future rather than live IN the past. I am learning that any change is palatable if you are anchored in one unchanging truth. And for me it is the complete active engagement with my future - which happens to be connected to yours and everyone else's. That is what connects all of us. It doesn't divide like identity does, it confuses, it intermeshes, it weaves us together. Walt Whitman's line comes to mind: "every atom belonging to me, as good belongs to you"

So if I am creating art for the future it has to take into account that the future is connected and distributed.

This is what I see when I see people focused on the past - imminent figures stuck to the past. You know, this feels like broken people walking backwards. We should be facing the future and preparing ourselves to transcend our current selves and move to embrace our future selves. This should be true of us as individuals and you know what, this is true of us as a society too!

We are not homo sapiens but homo mutans. We are the apes who change, who **can** change. The world we will inherit will be dreamt up by all of us. And we need to begin that dreaming now!



A.I. REPLACING LABOR

Currently Karthik and I believe that there are two big Elephants in the room that are threatening to tell me what my future is going to look like. Artificial Intelligence and Climate change.

AI is replacing all forms of labor. Can it replace me? Never, but will it be instrumental in shaping who I become. Without a doubt. If that is the case, then I have to and will engage with it now. **I will accept that we are all Cyborgs.** But then I will also have to craft what this relationship does to me, rather than be swept along like flotsam on a tide. And this is true of us as a society too!

WHAT'S NEXT

This has dared me to dream up the world alongside governments, scientists, engineers and priests. I can only do this if I stop looking backwards and start facing the future. I have a lot of imagining to do and a lot of creating ahead..

It is a call to reimagine through art life. To reimagine the social systems I remain trapped in, the political systems I take for granted, the very pattern of our reactions to life events which I think are natural. And artists can do this. They after all are the creators of new sensibilities!

Transcendence is not easy - but necessary!

Raghava KK

September 2018





Here are some things I've learnt through my relationship

1. Giving love and receiving love are very different activities. Confusing them as related turns love into a transaction.
2. Years go by and we never stop to ask what this Netra or this Raghava wants from the relationship. I'm glad we've had the opportunity to ask ourselves this recently.
3. I still believe in unconditional love.
4. What attracts you to someone is often what you need to overcome.
5. Sometimes I've thought that my intent is more important than the impact of my actions. I'm proven wrong.
6. Loving each other even when we have disliked each other is so special.
7. I've realized that there comes a time when we try to reason or justify a relationship. It's pointless and hurtful.
8. My father taught me that there is no object of love. You never love someone. You only love - period.
9. Wanting to be right comes in the way of accepting wrong and imperfect as beautiful. Mostly within yourself.
10. Passion is the opposite of familiarity. So sometimes it's best to keep a few mysteries alive.

Hope we remain witnesses to each other's lives forever.
I'm writing this note to ask you, my friends to hold me accountable to these learnings as I continue to love!!

Thank you



Raghava KK

Raghava KK, Named by CNN as one of the 10 most remarkable people of 2010, is a multidisciplinary artist and storyteller whose work is shown in galleries and museums around the world. In 2011, Raghava's iPad book "Pop-it" shook up the concept of the ideal family and won a Kirkus Book Award for Best of 2011. He was inducted into the National Geographic society for bringing together art science and technology. He is a co-founder of 64/1, a curation and research collective focused on building public understanding of how artists and artificial intelligence can come together to create art for the post-human age. Raghava is a four-time TED speaker, and he has lectured at several universities and art institutions, including NYU, Carnegie Mellon, the Ecole des Beaux-Arts, etc. He serves on the NuVu advisory and has also advised the INK Conference, Singularity University etc.

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Artmatr

Engineering for Art

Artmatr is an international community of artists and engineers working to merge digital technology with traditional painting methods.

Our Labs are designed around generating feedback between tool-makers and visual artists of all kinds. Artists and engineers mix it up with both cutting-edge and old-school technologies to expand boundaries of artists' creative potential. The result: an unprecedented art/tech playground for anyone of any age, technical background, or discipline to make outrageously innovative work.



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